



III



KINGS & PROPHETS

STUDY GUIDE • 3 OF 5

kingdom, exile and hope

1 SAMUEL – NEHEMIAH, ISAIAH, JEREMIAH

// START HERE

Welcome to Kings and Prophets

Welcome to Kings and Prophets. Over eight weeks we follow Israel's story from asking for a king to exile and return: Saul and David, a promise to David's house, Elijah, Isaiah's vision and the suffering servant, the fall of Jerusalem and a promised new covenant, and the return. These chapters show leaders who fail, prophets who speak, and a God who keeps promising hope. We read for what the text says, ask honest questions and leave each week with one step to try. Come ready to listen to Scripture and to one another.

◆ 01 How a session works

90 MIN

The same rhythm every week, so the group can relax into it.

GATHER · 10 MIN

Follow up on last week's step. Did you do it?

READ · 10 MIN

Scripture read aloud, then notes.

DISCUSS · 35 MIN

Questions, not a lecture. Everyone speaks.

ACT · 15 MIN

One step, one outward habit, then prayer.

◆ 02 What you need

BRING

- ◆ A Bible in a translation you trust
- ◆ This guide and a pen
- ◆ Anything else

BETWEEN MEETINGS

- ◆ A few minutes a day with the passage
- ◆ One step to act on
- ◆ One person to tell

◆ 03 About the passages

This guide gives **references only** and does not print Bible text, so read from your own Bible. If you paste text into a page, use a public-domain translation such as the KJV or WEB. Old Testament references use Hebrew-Bible chapter and verse numbering; where an English Bible differs, the English reference is in parentheses. This guide has 8 sessions, in canon order, as part of a five-guide journey from Genesis to Revelation.

// THE FRAME

Our group

Small, steady and weekly. Fixing these early is what lets people open up.

SIZE

6-12

people. Small enough that everyone speaks.

RHYTHM

Weekly

same day, time and place.

SEASON

8

weeks with a steady membership, then regroup.

01 Details

DAY · TIME

Day, time

PLACE

Address or room

LEADER

Name

FACILITATOR
ROTATION

Who leads which weeks

SEASON

Start – end date

CHILDCARE /
FOOD

Plan

GROUP CHAT

Link or name

OPEN / CLOSED

Closed for the season

NEXT SEASON

When we regroup

02 Roster

#	NAME	CONTACT	PRAYER OR CARE NOTE
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			
8			
9			
10			

// AGREED TOGETHER

Our ground rules

Write them, read them aloud in week one, and sign. Edit freely: these are starting points, not commandments.

- 1 Show up and stay for the whole season.
- 2 What is shared here stays here.
- 3 Everyone speaks; no one dominates.
- 4 We may challenge one another kindly, and we agree to be challenged.
- 5 Let Scripture lead; opinions come second.
- 6 Pray for each other between meetings.
- 7 Your own rule

PHRASES FOR CHALLENGING KINDLY

- ◆ "Can you say more about that?"
- ◆ "What does the text say?"
- ◆ "What would it cost you to do that?"
- ◆ Your own phrase

WHEN A RULE IS BROKEN

How we will handle it: who speaks to whom, and how soon.

◆ We agree

Initials and date.

NAME

INITIALS

DATE

// CHOOSE HOW YOU READ

Four ways to study a passage

This guide assigns a method to each session. Change it if your group prefers another.

METHOD 1

Inductive

- ◆ Observe: what does it say?
- ◆ Interpret: what does it mean?
- ◆ Apply: what does it ask of me?

Best for: close reading

METHOD 2

Discovery Bible Study

- ◆ What does it say?
- ◆ What does it say about God? About people?
- ◆ What will I obey?
- ◆ Whom will I tell?

Best for: groups new to the Bible

METHOD 3

Lectio divina

- ◆ Read: a short passage, slowly
- ◆ Meditate: one phrase
- ◆ Pray: respond to God
- ◆ Rest: be still, then share

Best for: prayerful, quieter weeks

METHOD 4

Short accountability

- ◆ Did I do what I said?
- ◆ What did I read this week?
- ◆ Where did I struggle?
- ◆ Whom did I tell or serve?

Best for: pairs, or the opening of any session

◆ Methods in this guide

This guide uses Discovery, Inductive, Lectio divina. Short accountability opens every session in the “Gather” step.

// 8 WEEKS

Our season at a glance

The arc is set; adjust as you go.

WEEK	PASSAGE	THEME	METHOD	LEADS
1	1 Samuel 8; 16:1–13	A king like the nations; a shepherd chosen	Inductive	Name
2	1 Samuel 17	David and Goliath	Discovery	Name
3	2 Samuel 7	God's promise to David	Inductive	Name
4	1 Kings 18	Elijah on Carmel	Lectio divina	Name
5	Isaiah 6	Isaiah's vision	Lectio divina	Name
6	Isaiah 52:13–53:12	The suffering servant	Discovery	Name
7	2 Kings 25:1–12; Jeremiah 31:30–33 (31:31–34 English)	Exile and the new covenant	Inductive	Name
8	Ezra 1; Nehemiah 8:1–12	Return and rebuild	Inductive	Name

LAST WEEK OF THE SEASON

Celebrate, review what changed, and decide whether to continue, regroup or multiply. Each guide in this set continues the story in canon order, from Genesis to Revelation.

// SESSION 1 OF 8 · INDUCTIVE

A king like the nations; a shepherd chosen

1 SAMUEL 8; 16:1-13 · LEADS: NAME · DATE

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Welcome everyone. Read the ground rules aloud (page 4) and share names.

WARM-UP

What leader (good or bad) shaped your life?

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read 1 Samuel 8; 16:1-13 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

1 SAMUEL 8; 16:1-13

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

1 **OBSERVE** Why do the elders ask for a king (8:4-5, 19-20)? What does Samuel warn will happen (8:10-18)?

2 **INTERPRET** What does God mean by saying they have rejected him (8:7)? How does the choice of David differ from what people expect (16:6-7, 10-13)?

3 **APPLY** What do you look at when you assess people, and what does 16:7 say God looks at? How could that change how you treat someone?

4 **CHALLENGE KINDLY** How do we talk about leaders (church or public) without it turning into a fight? What do we owe our leaders and what do we owe each other?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

Pray daily for one leader by name, even one you disagree with, and do something kind for someone overlooked.

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Serve someone behind the scenes: thank a leader who rarely hears it.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5-10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read 1 Samuel 16:1-13.

DAY 2

List how you judge by appearance.

DAY 3

Pray for the leaders in your life.

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// SESSION 2 OF 8 · DISCOVERY

David and Goliath

1 SAMUEL 17 · LEADS: NAME · DATE

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Did you do last week's step? What happened?

WARM-UP

Tell about a time you faced something much bigger than you.

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read 1 Samuel 17 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

1 SAMUEL 17

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

1 **OBSERVE** How do Saul and the army react to Goliath (17:11, 17:24)? What does David say and refuse (17:32–40)?

2 **INTERPRET** David says the battle belongs to the LORD (17:45–47). What does that mean for how he fights? What else could the story be about besides courage?

3 **APPLY** What “giant” are you facing? What has God already put in your hands?

4 **CHALLENGE KINDLY** This story is often used as a pep talk. What does it lose if we make it only about beating our problems?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

What will I obey? Take one concrete step toward a difficult situation. Whom will I tell?

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Stand with someone who feels outmatched: go with them to an appointment or hearing.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5–10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read Psalm 27.

DAY 2

Write down your giant.

DAY 3

Pray for someone facing theirs.

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// SESSION 3 OF 8 · INDUCTIVE

God's promise to David

2 SAMUEL 7 · LEADS: NAME · DATE

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Did you do last week's step? What happened?

WARM-UP

What is the biggest gift you have received that you did not earn?

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read 2 Samuel 7 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

2 SAMUEL 7

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

1 **OBSERVE** What does David want to build for God (7:1-3), and what does God say through Nathan (7:4-11)? What does God promise instead (7:11-16)?

2 **INTERPRET** God says he will build David a house, meaning a dynasty (7:11-16). What does it mean that the promise depends on God's action? How does David respond in prayer (7:18-29)?

3 **APPLY** Where do you try to do something for God that God wants to do for you? What would it mean to receive?

4 **CHALLENGE KINDLY** Jewish and Christian readers see this promise fulfilled in different ways. What can we all hear about God keeping his word?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

Receive something this week without paying it back: accept a gift or help, and thank God.

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Give a gift with no strings: pay for someone's meal or give anonymously.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5-10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read 2 Samuel 7:18-29.

DAY 2

Write one thing you try to earn.

DAY 3

Pray David's prayer in your own words.

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// SESSION 4 OF 8 • LECTIO DIVINA

Elijah on Carmel

1 KINGS 18 • LEADS: NAME DATE

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Did you do last week's step? What happened?

WARM-UP

Describe a high followed by a crash.

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read 1 Kings 18 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

1 KINGS 18

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

1 **OBSERVE** What does Elijah ask the people on Carmel (18:21), and what happens (18:36–39)? What follows in 1 Kings 19:1–4?

2 **INTERPRET** God feeds Elijah and speaks in a still small voice (19:5–8, 19:12; wording varies by translation). What does this say about how God meets us when we are exhausted?

3 **APPLY** When have you felt like Elijah, saying “I alone am left” (19:10)? Who or what helped, and who could help now?

4 **CHALLENGE KINDLY** God answers that seven thousand have not bowed (19:18). How do we encourage one another honestly when we feel isolated or burned out?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

Rest and eat well this week; tell one friend how you are really doing and ask for one thing.

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Bring a meal or rest to a caregiver, pastor or nurse who is burned out.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5–10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read 1 Kings 19:1–18.

DAY 2

Write what exhausts you.

DAY 3

Pray in quiet for five minutes and listen.

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// SESSION 5 OF 8 · LECTIO DIVINA

Isaiah's vision

ISAIAH 6 · LEADS: NAME · DATE

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Did you do last week's step? What happened?

WARM-UP

What is the most awe-inspiring place you have been?

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read Isaiah 6 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

ISAIAH 6

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

1 OBSERVE What does Isaiah see and hear (6:1-4)? How does he respond (6:5), and what happens next (6:6-7)?

2 INTERPRET What does the vision show about God's holiness and about human sin? What does God ask, and how does Isaiah answer (6:8)?

3 APPLY Where do you need to hear that your guilt is taken away, or that you are sent? What would it look like to say "Here am I"?

4 CHALLENGE KINDLY This passage includes a hard message for Isaiah's hearers (6:9-13). How do we handle difficult parts of Scripture honestly?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

Spend five minutes in silence each day this week in God's presence, and ask what you are being sent to do.

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Volunteer for something you have been avoiding; answer a request for help.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5-10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read Isaiah 6:1-8.

DAY 2

Write what you hear when you pray.

DAY 3

Pray "Here am I."

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// SESSION 6 OF 8 · DISCOVERY

The suffering servant

ISAIAH 52:13–53:12 · LEADS: NAME · DATE

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Did you do last week's step? What happened?

WARM-UP

Who in your life has carried a burden for you?

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read Isaiah 52:13–53:12 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

ISAIAH 52:13–53:12

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

- 1 **OBSERVE** What is said about the servant's appearance and treatment (52:14; 53:2–3, 53:7–9)? What do the speakers say they did and what was done for them (53:4–6)?

- 2 **INTERPRET** The passage speaks of the servant bearing the sins of many (53:4–6, 53:10–12). Who is the servant? Why do readers answer this differently?

- 3 **APPLY** What does this passage ask you to see about suffering, innocence and being carried?

- 4 **CHALLENGE KINDLY** Jewish tradition often reads the servant as Israel; Christians often read him as Jesus. How can we explain our own reading plainly and listen respectfully to the others?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

What will I obey? Do something for someone that costs you time or comfort. Whom will I tell?

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Care for someone who suffers unjustly, such as a person in prison or a refugee.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5–10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read Isaiah 53 slowly.

DAY 2

Write what stands out about the servant.

DAY 3

Pray for someone who is suffering.

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// SESSION 7 OF 8 · INDUCTIVE

Exile and the new covenant

2 KINGS 25:1-12; JEREMIAH 31:30-33 (31:31-34 ENGLISH) · LEADS: NAME · DATE

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Did you do last week's step? What happened?

WARM-UP

Have you ever lived somewhere that did not feel like home?

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read 2 Kings 25:1-12; Jeremiah 31:30-33 (31:31-34 English) aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

2 KINGS 25:1-12; JEREMIAH 31:30-33 (31:31-34 ENGLISH)

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

1 **OBSERVE** What happens to Jerusalem and its people (2 Kings 25:1-12)? What does God promise in Jeremiah 31:30-33 (31:31-34 in English Bibles)?

2 **INTERPRET** What will be different about the new covenant: where is the Law written, and what does God say about knowing him and forgiving sin (31:32-33)?

3 **APPLY** Where do you feel in exile or far from home? How might you hold both honest grief and hope for what God promises?

4 **CHALLENGE KINDLY** Christians and Jews read the new covenant differently. What can we say together about God's promise to change hearts?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

Write down one grief and one hope. Share them with your partner and pray for one another.

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Seek the good of your city: join a local effort or pray for the people of your neighborhood.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5-10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read Jeremiah 31:30-33.

DAY 2

Write where you feel in exile.

DAY 3

Pray for your city.

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// SESSION 8 OF 8 • INDUCTIVE

Return and rebuild

EZRA 1; NEHEMIAH 8:1-12 • LEADS: NAME • DATE

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Did you do last week's step? What happened?

WARM-UP

When has something rebuilt felt both joyful and sad?

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read Ezra 1; Nehemiah 8:1-12 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

EZRA 1; NEHEMIAH 8:1-12

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

- 1 **OBSERVE** How does the return begin (Ezra 1:1-4)? What do the people do when Ezra reads the Law (Nehemiah 8:1-6), and how do they respond (8:9-12)?

- 2 **INTERPRET** Why do the people weep when they hear the Law, and why does Nehemiah tell them not to grieve (8:9-10)? What does this show about how God's word works on people?

- 3 **APPLY** What do you need to rebuild: a habit, a relationship, trust? Where do you need to hear God's word read again?

- 4 **CHALLENGE KINDLY** The return did not restore everything. How do we hold gratitude and grief together, in the church and in ourselves?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

Choose one thing to rebuild with small daily steps, and read a Bible passage aloud with someone. Plan what comes next for the group.

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Help rebuild something for others, such as a home repair or community project.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5-10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read Nehemiah 8:1-12.

DAY 2

Write what you grieve and what you give thanks for.

DAY 3

Pray for what you are rebuilding.

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// PERSONAL REFLECTION

Five days, five short moments

The strongest measured predictor of spiritual growth is reading and reflecting on your own between meetings. Ten minutes is enough. Use the passage from your next session.

◆ 01 Read

10 MIN

Read the week's passage slowly, once. Note the reference.

◆ 02 Notice

10 MIN

Write one line: what stands out?

◆ 03 Ask

10 MIN

Write one question you would ask God about it.

◆ 04 Do

10 MIN

Take this week's step. What happened?

◆ 05 Pray

10 MIN

Pray for the person or place outside the group.

BRING TO NEXT SESSION

One thing you noticed, one question, one result from your step.

// TOGETHER AND BEYOND

Prayer requests

NAME	REQUEST	DATE	ANSWERED

◆ Beyond the group

An outward-facing habit keeps the group from turning inward: people and places we pray for or serve outside the circle.

WHO OR WHERE	PRAY / SERVE	WHEN	DONE

◆ Season project (optional)

One thing we do together for others.

Seek the good of your city together: partner with a local school, shelter or neighborhood group for a service day.

Project, date, who is leading · Your plan

// FOR THE LEADER

Leader's notes

The leader guides; the group discovers. Ask, listen, and resist teaching the whole passage.

BEFORE

- ◆ Read the passage twice and note your own questions
- ◆ Pick the method and rehearse the four questions
- ◆ Pray for each person by name

AFTER

- ◆ Text a note to anyone who was quiet
- ◆ Log the steps people named
- ◆ Your own follow-up

◆ 01 Timing guide

90 MIN

PART	MIN	NOTES
Gather & follow up	10	<u>Notes</u>
Open in prayer	3	<u>Notes</u>
Read	10	<u>Notes</u>
Discuss	35	<u>Notes</u>
This week's step	10	<u>Notes</u>
Beyond the group · prayer	12	<u>Notes</u>
Buffer	10	<u>Notes</u>

◆ 02 Hard moments in this guide

LEADERS AND POWER

Kings and prophets often meet political topics. Keep to what the text says about leaders and God, and keep conversations about current politics out of the circle.

ISAIAH AND THE MESSIAH

Jewish and Christian readers interpret Isaiah 53 and the promises of a coming king differently. Name that respectfully and let each tradition speak for itself.

GRIEF AND EXILE

Exile passages involve loss and lament. Allow silence and honest sorrow; do not hurry to the hopeful ending.

◆ 03 Session notes

WHY THIS STRUCTURE

Groups reliably build belonging and forgiveness, but showing up does not by itself deepen Bible knowledge or growth. The design leans on discussion, written ground rules, a step to act on, personal reflection between meetings and an outward habit. The 6-12 size and 8-12 week season are practitioner advice, not a measured result.

// SESSION BY SESSION

What to watch for

A short note for each week. Edit freely.

WEEK	PASSAGE	WATCH FOR
1	1 Samuel 8; 16:1–13	Political tension can rise quickly. Keep to the text's question: who leads God's people and how.
2	1 Samuel 17	Avoid triumphalism. Some members face giants that do not go away (illness, grief), so make room for them.
3	2 Samuel 7	The text describes David's house and a promise, and traditions read it differently. Invite the group to say what they see in the text before moving to later fulfillment.
4	1 Kings 18	Depression and burnout may surface. Affirm rest and professional help; do not spiritualize everything.
5	Isaiah 6	Avoid explaining away the hard sending in 6:9–13. Acknowledge it is difficult and move on to what 6:1–8 shows.
6	Isaiah 52:13–53:12	This is a passage where Jewish and Christian readings differ. Keep a respectful tone, avoid claiming other readings are wrong, and let guests speak for themselves.
7	2 Kings 25:1–12; Jeremiah 31:30–33 (31:31–34 English)	Exile involves real loss. Allow lament, and do not hurry the group toward the promise.
8	Ezra 1; Nehemiah 8:1–12	Some will connect to grief over a church or family. Give space, and use this last session to review the season and plan what is next.